

Play Things: Children's Racialized Mechanical Banks and Toys, 1880-1930

Christopher P. Barton & Kyle Somerville

Int J Histor Archaeol (2012) 16:47-85 | DOI 10.1007/s10761-012-0169-y

Published online: 21 February 2012 | Springer Science+Business Media, LLC 2012

Abstract

The reproduction of racism and class-based oppression are taught to children through various cultural media, including toys and games. Between 1880 and 1930, the popularity of racialized toys and banks were fear-based responses to the perceived encroachment by "foreign and exotic" migrations of African American, Chinese, Irish and Native Americans into the cultural landscape of white middle-class America. This article analyzes how artifacts associated with children, such as mechanical banks, clockwork figures, and other toys are part of a larger cultural structure that viewed race and class as inseparable, and that these objects were essential in the development of a learned habitus that exposed white middle class children in the Victorian era to a racially and class oriented world. We argue that these objects reflect both the times in which they were made, and illuminate the relationship between adults and a newfound emphasis on children and childhood, in which toys serves as symbolic mediators of culture.

Keywords: Toys . Racism . Racialization . Victorian America

Introduction

Children and childhood have increasingly become a popular topic of archaeological research (i.e., Baxter 2005; Dommasnes and Wrigglesworth 2008; Lillehammer 1989; Sofaer Derevenski 2000). Within historical archaeology, most of this research has centered on toys recovered from Victorian working-class archaeological contexts (see, for example, Engmann 2007; Wilkie 2000; Yamin 2002). In this paper, we examine toys that were made and sold specifically towards white, middle-class Victorian consumers and which depict racial stereotypes of African Americans, Irish, Chinese, and Native Americans, and, significantly, which are unlikely to be found in traditional archaeological contexts. While much work has been devoted to the stereotypes and motifs depicted on racial toys (i.e., Barrett 2003; Wilkinson 1974), less has been done to explain these objects as the products of both cultural values and larger sociocultural movements emerging in the United States during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.

As items made specifically for children from a defined socioeconomic middle class, and a "white" race, from what historical context do these items emerge, and how are they connected with larger social and demographic movements? In what capacity do they serve as a medium of communication between adults and children, as an avenue of racial socialization? The purpose of this paper is therefore twofold. First, we seek to trace the emergence of these toys from a particular time and place, the United States from approximately 1880-1930. Second, we will analyze these toys as objects used by adults to expose

children into a class based, racist culture. As the historian Doris Wilkinson (1974, p. 100) put it:

"Play objects are not merely items for fun, but function directly and indirectly to maintain existing beliefs and behavioral systems. They are not material trivialities... Both games and toys provide a looking-glass reflection of the larger society; and one cannot offer a meaningful commentary on these cultural artifacts without evaluating them in the broader network of the systems in which they were constructed and in which they were played."

The Roots of Modern Racism

American constructions of racism solidified during the Victorian period (1837-1901), defined by years of the reign of Britain's Queen Victoria (Howe 1977). These decades were a time in which the wonders and promises of technological progress coexisted with the very real social problems associated with capitalism, industrialization and urbanization. Within the United States, the vast numbers of immigrants flooding into American cities resulted in a new awareness of the differences between middle class practices and values, and those of the new immigrant populations. The construction of the "white" race within American society was based on such migrations of people who were phenotypically and cultural perceived as different from the white middle class. In a world that was becoming less concerned with identifying people as being either "Christian" or "Non-Christian" the application of labels such as Red, Black, Yellow, or Irish were used to perpetuate inferiority in contrast to the "White" race in America (Paynter 2001, pp. 134-135).

This awareness, or "cultural self-consciousness", as Howe (1977) terms it, is ultimately reflected in the toys depicting racial stereotypes that were produced during this time. Howe (1977, p. 24) further suggests that Victorian racism was a "tragic contradiction," an amalgam of "traditional ethnocentric habits" combined with nationalism and racism. This "tragic contradiction" inherent in white Victorian culture manifested itself in hostility towards outsiders: that is to say, all those peoples and cultures that did not fit easily into the tightly ordered (white, middle-class) Victorian cosmology. In addition, the development of Darwinism and eugenics based scientific perceptions of racially defined categorizations perpetuated widely held ideologies of white racial and cultural superiority.

Exposing children to racialized toys is but one facet of the white, middle-class Anglo-American habitus (Bourdieu 1977), intended to make children of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries maintain both unspoken and explicitly held beliefs on the superiority of their biologically defined "white race," enabling children to identify practices, beliefs and behaviors that were considered to be outside of white middle-class America. When situations change, the responses and reactions to other "races" would continue to be products of the habitus of children who have been socialized within the structures of racism.

There are a few points we wish to clarify before going further. Although we will suggest that the high cost of these toys would have made them available predominantly only to people with disposable incomes, that is to say, the white middle class, these objects lack a firm archaeological context, which precludes clear statements of gender or class association and possession of the toys mentioned here. This includes their ownership by the very groups which the toys presume to depict. Meaning is dependent on context, and because these objects have been pulled out of their contexts of their original child owners, if they ever had a child owner at all, make it extremely difficult to examine the role these toys played in dialogues of the (re)formation of identity between adults and children. That said, we believe that the "salvage principle" (Wylie 1996), wherein artifacts taken out of context can still be

excellent sources of information about past beliefs and practices, is a suitable defense for both of these stipulations.

Methodology and Data

Toys, in the modern sense of mass-produced objects made specifically for and used exclusively by children, are products of the Industrial Revolution. The mass manufacture of toys in the United States began during the mid-nineteenth century, piggybacking upon technological innovations in other areas of industry. Sheet metal stamping, cast iron manufacture, improved ceramic molding techniques, lithographic printing and cardboard making enabled the cheap and efficient mass production of a large variety of toys such as dolls, trains, books and board games (Chudacoff 2007). Toy manufacture quickly became big business in both Europe (Ganaway 2007), and the United States: for example, in 1850, the number of toy manufacturers in the United States was 47. By 1880, that number had nearly quadrupled to 173, and included now-familiar names such as Milton Bradley and Parker Brothers (Chudacoff 2007, p. 74).

A sample database of 103 toys exhibiting racial caricatures or stereotypes was compiled using data acquired from antique dealer and collectors' websites, period advertising and catalogs, patent papers, and museum collections. From these sources, the data collected included toy type (i.e. mechanical bank), description of the toy from period advertising if applicable, name of the manufacturer (or distributor if the manufacturer is unknown), date of first manufacture/appearance in advertising, and price.

The breakdown of this 103 toy sample is as follows: 48 mechanical banks (46.6%) (three of which are mechanical/clockwork hybrids), four still (non-mechanical) banks (3.8%), 32 clockwork (windup) toys (31%), three mechanical push/pull toys (2.9%), four target shooting games (3.8%), five cap pistols (4.8%), three dolls/doll sets (2.9%), two costumes (1.9%), and two board games (1.9%). All of these toys range in date from 1879 to 1934.

Based on the number of styles and their variants, the mechanical bank appears to be the most common form of the racialized toy, and "is a peculiarly American phenomenon" (Lederer 1940). The toy bank, a didactic object in itself used to teach the virtue of thrift (Somerville in press), was an incredibly popular toy with over 600 different varieties and 280 mechanical variants produced between 1875 and 1910 (Emerine 1941), with a minimum of 10,000 individual toys produced from a single mold (Lederer 1940).

The vast majority of mechanical banks were patented and produced by just three companies: the Shepard Hardware Company of Buffalo, New York, the J. & E. Stevens Company of Cromwell, Connecticut, and the Kyser and Rex Company of Philadelphia, Pennsylvania. According to Griffith (1963a), the J. & E. Stevens Company was the most prolific of these manufacturers, responsible for approximately one third of all known mechanical bank designs. However, the most prolific inventor of mechanical banks was Charles Bailey, a toymaker who designed or patented at least 29 different banks, 10% of all known examples, including several banks with racial themes including "Darkey Fisherman," "Chinaman in Boat," "Dentist," "Darky and Watermelon," and "Bad Accident," and who also worked at J. & E. Stevens for nearly 25 years (Griffith 1963b).

Despite their apparently large numbers, mechanical toys of all kinds were expensive (Cross 1997; Ganaway 2007; Museum of American Heritage 1998). Most mechanical banks cost between \$.45 and

\$1.15, excluding postage, and averaged approximately \$.85 and up. Indeed, the prices for these objects were considered "rather steep" for the times (The Antiques Journal 1961), making them available only to relatively affluent customers.

Discussion

The toys discussed in this article vividly illustrate the divide between what Baxter (2005, p. 46) terms the "imperial practices of adults" and the "native practices of children." Adults perceive toys much differently than children do. Children are much more fluid than adults in what they consider to be toys, and a stick found in the yard quickly and easily becomes a sword or a magic wand. On the other hand, adults usually think of toys as a rigid class of object which is made exclusively for and given to children (Calvert 1992). Although Wilkie (2000, p. 100) is correct when she states that oftentimes "children's artifacts are discussed as byproducts of parents' attempts to instill values into their children, not as statements made by children," the practice of marketing directly towards children did not emerge until the twentieth century (Cook 2004, p. 71; Jacobson 2008, p. 4). Therefore, these racialized toys are much more reflective of adult views and values, and were made to appeal to adults who would purchase them.

In industrial capitalism, manufacturers are quick to capitalize on popular issues, and as objects of mass manufacture, toys are often highly topical, and can serve as temporal markers of the obsessions of popular culture. In this regard, toys are a sort of barometer and it is not coincidental that racial toys were popular during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, a time in which white culture was on the offensive against the intrusion of the "exotic other" onto the American landscape. Hence, racial toys also serve as temporal markers, reflecting undercurrents of popular attitudes towards immigrants and non-whites. For the projection of racialized images onto toys and mechanical banks the manufacturer must be able to reproduce a stereotyped representation of the group being depicted that the audience can easily identify.

Native Americans

Eight toys (7.6% of the total sample) show depictions of Native Americans. Beginning in the post-Civil War era and continuing well into the 1930s, the depiction of Native Americans on artifacts intended for children represented in two distinct forms in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries: as violent heathens who were impeding the progress of White America and as the "noble savage." As the United States grew into a capitalist society that emphasized individuality and materialism as hallmarks of social progress, Native Americans became stereotyped by middle-class white America as the antithesis of capitalism and mainstream values.

The post-Civil War perception of Native Americans reflected racist stereotypes and ideologies of Native Americans as blood thirsty clannish savages who were obstacles to the United States in fulfilling its Manifest Destiny. These beliefs of the savagery of Native Americans are reproduced onto children's toys in the form of shooting gallery targets such as the Popgun and Exceptional Shooting games of 1923 and 1929, respectively, in which cardboard figures of Native Americans were included alongside safari animals as the targets for white children.

The second racialized stereotype of Native American to be projected onto children's toys and banks is that of the defeated "noble savage." This depiction finds its origins in the Romantic Era and its rejection

of rationality and industrialization. As Native people's populations decrease due to the actions of genocide conducted by the United States government and the threat of these uncivilized hordes of heathens diminish, the stereotype of the "Injun" begins to shift into a nostalgic remembrance of an era before industrialization. The "New Game of Migration" illustrates this well: the player moves a group of Native Americans from one corner of the board to a reservation on the opposite, teaching that the proper place for Native Americans was to be stashed away in a corner (or reservation), far away from the white world.

Irish

A single toy, the "Paddy and the Pig/Shamrock Bank" mechanical bank (.9% of the total sample), portrays a stereotyped depiction of the Irish. The racialization of the Irish is largely based on British constructions of the Irish being an inferior, uncivilized horde (Brighton 2008; Orser 2007; Shackel 2003). Within the United States, Nativist attention on the Irish as a threat to White American was rooted in employment competition, biological evolution, and religious concerns over Catholicism. Following the Great Hunger (Great Famine) beginning in 1843, almost 2 million Irish migrants came to the United States in search of a new home. The majority of Irish immigrants were poor rural farm workers with limited economic and social capital. Without industrial occupational skills, the Irish in America served mainly as cheap labor or domestic servants.

The connection between the Irish and African Americans was not only based on their low end positioning but also rooted in phenotypic stereotypes. Ignatiev (1995) documents Nativist references of the Irish being "niggers turned inside out" as well as African Americans being "smoked Irish." In creating a connection between the poor Irish and African Americans, white Americans solidified and justified the subjugated position of inferior races through phenotypic stereotypes. With the rise of scientific race based typologies the Irish came to be viewed as a subcategory of human that had yet to fully evolve.

However, at the turn of the twentieth century, as the Irish achieved greater political and social clout through their support of the Democratic Party, nativist hostility shifted away from them. The lack of toys depicting the Irish appears to coincide with the greater political and social clout achieved by the Irish, as anti-"new" immigrant rhetoric refocused on groups from eastern and southern Europe, and the migration of African Americans helped to shift attention away from the non-white status of the "Irish" race (Orser 2007, p. 90).

Chinese

A total of ten toys (9.7% of the total sample) depict Chinese stereotypes. Following the 1849 California Gold Rush, the migration of Chinese into the United States aroused steady ire until Nativist legislation through the Chinese Exclusionary Act halted legal immigration. The vast majority of the Chinese population living in the U.S. was economically oppressed males who had fled China following the Opium Wars (Orser 2007). As a result of such hardships many of these Chinese immigrants were employed as unskilled laborers working in mining camps or on railroads.

Like that against the Irish, the racialization of the Chinese in the nineteenth century by "white" America was largely based upon three key factors: phenotypic stereotypes, religious difference, and employment competition. A recurring element that was used by toy manufacturers to make the consumer identify that the toy was of a "Chinaman" was the presence of the queue, the distinctive long

"pigtail" worn by Chinese men as a symbol of masculinity. Of the ten toys depicting Chinese stereotypes, eight (80%) of them are of men with queues.

The most commonly uttered complaint against the Chinese in the Victorian Era was that "White" America viewed the Chinese as inferior based on employment competition. With the rise of union activism in the United States many companies used Chinese immigrants as strikebreakers, consequently infuriating white working-class Americans who viewed the ever-growing Chinese community as a direct threat to their livelihood, resulting in cries that the "Importation of Chinese Barbarians into the Country Must Be Stopped by the Ballot or Bullet." The rise to prominence of the Know Nothing party and their Nativist agenda brought the production of toys such as "The Chinese Must Go!" cap gun, which depicted a Nativist holding a Chinese man's queue, and when the trigger is pulled the Nativist kicks the Chinese man in the behind, setting off the cap in Chinese man's mouth.

African Americans

No racial group was depicted more frequently on Victorian children's toys than African Americans, a fact reflected by our data sample: of the 103 toys, 83 (80.5%) depict African Americans. Indeed, "Of all the American popular genres using African-American imagery, children's games have been among the most uniformly negative" (Mercier n.d.). The process of African American racialization has been discussed at length elsewhere (see, for example, Berlin 1998; Orser 1998, 2004, 2007). While phenotypic differences played a major role in the racialization of African Americans, issues of stereotyped culture and class were also vital in the formation of the "Black" race.

Following emancipation, African Americans were still considered inferior to whites, an inferiority rooted in stereotypic phenotypes and class. When "scientific" applications of human evolution were applied to "the negro race" they, like the other groups discussed in this paper, were deemed to be biologically inferior to the Anglo-Saxon race. African Americans were economically and socially oppressed by a white culture that created both informal and formal institutions of racism in attempt to keep African Americans from obtaining capital. As a result of such racism and oppression African Americans were largely employed within economically low end employment. Ten (12%) of the eighty-three toys depict African Americans working in menial jobs such as washing, portering, and sharecropping.

A common theme is the portrayal of African Americans either dancing or playing musical instruments. The "Alabama Coon Jigger" sold 8 million units (Cross 1997, p. 99). The Jolly Coon Jigger exemplifies the intersection of economic and social habitus among white, middle-class America at the time. Children were taught not only the value of economic capital in a capitalist society but also the reproducing stereotype of the jovial dancing African American -- a race to be viewed by white children as their social inferior. In making African Americans appear as dancing fools with over-exaggerated physical features, a semiotic connection between the middle-class white children, the toy and African Americans was created. Thus, the inferiority of African Americans was not only based on class oppression but a socially constructed ideology of concrete racial differences.

Conclusion

As Baxter (2005, p. 40) notes, "The link between the social and material is inextricable, and material items do not constitute a separate superstructure to social worlds." Toys are not simply objects for play, but are also a medium of communication between children and adult. For Victorian America, ideologies

of race and class were inseparable (Roediger 1991). This juxtaposition of social constructs reproduced perceptions of white dominance within white Victorian America, of which their remnants are visible today. The learned habitus of such oppressive ideologies are recreated through time and space.

We have discussed how the habitus of white, Victorian America was represented in the form of artifacts associated with children. Toys and mechanical banks are but one way to observe how children became socialized into race/class based oppression, and such a medium of racism and its reproducing socialization can be readily observed within the archaeological record. The mass production of toys and banks depicting racialized imagery shows that in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, there existed not only a demand for such products but that the people were well versed in the stereotyped representations of the depicted racial groups.

Racialized toys say much more about the deeper cultural composition of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century America in which these toys were created, and the adults who purchased them, than the children who received them. Constructions of race and class social constructs reproduce ideologies of white superiority which contrast with "inferior races." Such ideologies can still be easily observed today. Historical archaeologists, in particular, are in an excellent position to uncover how such ideologies are reproduced and altered over time and space. Although Victorian racialized toys are only one specific cultural medium of socialization, it is through this work that we can create discourse to see how such ideologies of racism persist in the present. In doing so, we hope to promote a better understanding of the development, reproduction, and alteration of the construction of race and identity in the United States.

Acknowledgments: Chris thanks David G. Orr, the anthropology department at Temple, and my loving wife Jess. Kyle thanks Sissie Pipes and Guner Coskunsu. We jointly thank Robert L. Schuyler for his guidance and support throughout our careers. Lastly, we give our sincere gratitude to Chris Fennell, Chris Matthews, Charles Orser, and two anonymous reviewers for their thoughtful comments on various drafts of this paper.

Appendix: Toy Sample

The following catalogues all 103 racialized toys in the study sample, organized by depicted group.

Native American Toys

Chief Big Moon

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Indian sitting in front of teepee holding a fish; deposited coin releases spring causing a hidden frog to leap for the fish; Indian pulls fish away when frog jumps.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Company, Cromwell, CT
Date: 1899 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Columbus Bank

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Coin placed at feet of Columbus triggers an Indian chief leaping from a log, extending the pipe of peace as Columbus salutes.
Manufacturer: Carl P. Stirn, New York City
Date: 1893-94 | Price: \$8.00/dozen
Source: Barlow 1998

Indian Shooting a Bear / Bear Hunt Bank

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Indian Warrior kneeling takes aim and shoots coin into chest of a bear by a stump; dressed in full regalia.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT
Date: 1883-88 | Price: \$0.85
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Indian Brave

Type: Still bank
Description: Indian warrior with headdress and tomahawk.
Manufacturer: Unknown
Date: Unknown (probably 20th century) | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanksonline.com

Game of the Wild West

Type: Board game
Description: Cowboys and Indians game.
Manufacturer: Marshall Field & Company
Date: 1890-93 | Price: Unknown
Source: Barlow 1998

New Game of Migration

Type: Board game
Description: Players move Native Americans from one corner of the board to a reservation on the opposite side.
Manufacturer: Marshall Field & Company
Date: 1890-93 | Price: \$5.35/dozen
Source: Barlow 1998

Exceptional Shooting Game

Type: Target game
Description: Eighteen colored figures including war painted Indians and soldiers, lined up as targets.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1929-32 | Price: \$0.49

Source: Spero 1988

Poppun Shooting Games

Type: Target game

Description: Break type popguns with corks, cardboard Indians and animals.

Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck

Date: ca. 1923 | Price: \$0.39-0.59

Source: Spero 1988

Irish Toy

Shamrock Bank / Paddy and the Pig

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Coin placed on pig's nose; lever pressed causes pig to strike coin with foot, man opens mouth, catches it on tongue and swallows it; eyes roll.

Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT

Date: 1882 | Price: \$9.00/dozen

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Asian (Chinese and Japanese) Toys

Chinaman in Boat

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: With rat on tray in bow of boat; press queue and Chinaman flips over table top, other side showing rat on tray.

Manufacturer: Charles A. Bailey, Cobalt, CT

Date: 1880s | Price: Unknown

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Reclining Chinaman

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Coin placed in pocket of Chinaman's smock; lever depressed causes arm to raise and expose hand of cards; coin drops into bank.

Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT

Date: 1882 | Price: Unknown

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Shoot that Hat

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Standing figure clamps hat onto seated figure; top of hat rises exposing face of a Chinaman; coin drops.

Manufacturer: Ives Co., Bridgeport, CT

Date: 1882 | Price: Unknown

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Chinaman Head

Type: Still bank

Description: Caricatured head of Chinese man, including queue.

Manufacturer: Unknown

Date: Unknown | Price: Unknown

Source: Mechanicalbanksonline.org

Coolie Wagon

Type: Clockwork toy

Description: Runs in circle; figure raises head out of wagon, coolie shakes head.

Manufacturer: Butler Bros., New York City
Date: 1925 | Price: \$4.25/dozen
Source: Barlow 1998

Chinaman Pulls his Cart

Type: Mechanical pull toy
Description: When wound up and released, figure walks along drawing cart; very lifelike.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1921 | Price: \$0.39
Source: Spero 1988

Chinese Head Cap Exploder

Type: Cap pistol
Description: Single and double faced versions.
Manufacturer: Unknown
Date: 1879-82 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Chinese Must Go

Type: Cap pistol
Description: Nativist holds Chinese man's queue; trigger pulled causes Nativist to kick Chinese man, setting off cap in mouth.
Manufacturer: Ives Co., Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1879 | Price: Unknown
Source: Thetoyzone.com

Shoot That Hat (pistol)

Type: Cap pistol
Description: Figure clamps hat on seated Chinaman, firing a paper cap inside the hat.
Manufacturer: Ives Co., Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1879-82 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Comical Head Shaking Doll

Type: Doll
Description: Heads wig-wag; includes boy, girl, and Chinaman figure.
Manufacturer: Butler Bros., New York City
Date: 1905 | Price: \$0.95/dozen
Source: Spero 1988

Mikado

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Japanese Magic Bank: coin placed under hat in Mikado's right hand; lever turned makes coin disappear and reappear under other hat; bells chime.
Manufacturer: Kyser and Rex, Philadelphia, PA
Date: 1887 | Price: \$0.95
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Doke's Tea Party

Type: Doll set
Description: Three Japanese wicker chairs, table, set china dishes, and three Japanese dolls.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1911 | Price: \$0.29
Source: Spero 1988

African American Toys

African Bank

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Stylized African savage head, similar in operation to Jolly Nigger Bank.
Manufacturer: Unknown, probably German
Date: ca. 1907 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Always Did 'Spise a Mule (jockey)

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Coin placed in rider's mouth; mule's heels flung up, rider thrown over head, coin shot into bank.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT
Date: 1879 | Price: \$0.95
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Always Did 'Spise a Mule (bench)

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Mule whirls and kicks darkey over, throwing coin from bench into receptacle.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT
Date: 1897 | Price: \$0.67
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Baby Mine / Mammy and Child

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Coin on large spoon fed into child's mouth; lever pressed causes child to kick feet, mammy nods head.
Manufacturer: Kyser and Rex, Philadelphia, PA
Date: 1884 | Price: \$0.85
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Bad Accident

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Coin placed under driver's feet; boy jumps into road, donkey frightened, rears up, coin falls into cart.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT
Date: 1888 | Price: \$9.00/dozen
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Bamboula

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Similar to Jolly Nigger.
Manufacturer: Unknown, probably French
Date: 1895-1910 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Beggar Bank

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: One-legged figure with hat; coin dropped into hat disappears while beggar nods in acknowledgement.
Manufacturer: H.L. Judd Mfg. Co., Wallingford, CT
Date: 1879 | Price: \$0.80
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Boys Stealing Watermelons

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Boy reaching for watermelon triggers dog to charge; base represents field of watermelon vines.

Manufacturer: Kyser and Rex, Philadelphia, PA
Date: 1885-95 | Price: \$3.60/4
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Cabin Bank

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Coin placed on roof above figure's head; handle moved causes figure to stand on head and kick coin into bank.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT
Date: 1885 | Price: \$0.54
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Dapper Dan

Type: Clockwork/mechanical bank
Description: Wind up and insert coin; figure dances a jig. Also sold as Thrifty Tom.
Manufacturer: Louis Marx and Co., New York City
Date: 1925 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Darktown Battery / Base Ball Bank

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Pitcher throws coin over plate; batter strikes at it; catcher misses; coin disappears in breast protector.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT
Date: 1888 | Price: \$0.90
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Darky Fisherman

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Base reads 'Dis Pond Am De Boss Place To Fish.'
Manufacturer: Charles A. Bailey, Cobalt, CT
Date: 1880-85 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Dentist

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Dentist falls backward, coin drops into coin bag; patient falls backward in chair, throwing arms up.
Manufacturer: J&E; Stevens Co., Cromwell, CT
Date: 1880-90 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Dinah / Long Sleeve Dinah

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Similar to Jolly Nigger, except woman.
Manufacturer: John Harper and Co., Ltd, Willenhall, England
Date: 1911 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanksonline.com

Foot Ball Bank / Darky and Watermelon

Type: Mechanical bank
Description: Coin placed in foot ball; spring pressed causes old Darkey to kick the ball over the watermelon, depositing coin.
Manufacturer: Charles A. Bailey, Cobalt, CT
Date: 1888 | Price: \$8.50/dozen
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Freedman's Saving Bank

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Figure sweeps coin into hole in counter, raises hand to nose and waves fingers satirically, then shakes head.

Manufacturer: Jerome B. Secor Mfg., Bridgeport, CT

Date: 1880 | Price: \$4.25

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Initiating First Degree

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Goat butts darky forward to deposit coin in mouth of frog rising on hind legs.

Manufacturer: Mechanical Novelty Works, New Britain, CT

Date: 1880-86 | Price: Unknown

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Jolly Nigger

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Coin thrown into mouth; eyes roll upward while tongue falls back. One of the most popular banks produced.

Manufacturer: Shepard Hardware Co., Buffalo, NY

Date: 1882 | Price: \$0.95

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Kicking Mule

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Coin placed on bench; lever pressed, mule turns and upsets darkey, depositing coin.

Manufacturer: Butler Bros., New York City

Date: 1921 | Price: \$1.75

Source: Barlow 1998

Stump Speaker

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Bootblack seated on box with outstretched hands; boy standing behind swings huge hat over his head; coin deposits.

Manufacturer: Shepard Hardware Co., Buffalo, NY

Date: 1886 | Price: \$8.75/dozen

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Uncle Remus

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Darky stands in chicken house; when sprung, door slams, policeman jumps forward; hen runs across lot.

Manufacturer: Kyser and Rex, Philadelphia, PA

Date: 1891 | Price: Unknown

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Weeden's Plantation Darky Bank

Type: Mechanical bank

Description: Sheet metal plantation shanty with clockwork; coin deposited triggers banjo player and dancer performing a breakdown.

Manufacturer: Weeden Mfg. Co., New Bedford, MA

Date: 1888 | Price: \$1.40

Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Picaninny

Type: Still bank

Description: "Please give me a penny." Made of malleable cast iron.

Manufacturer: Unknown, probably English
Date: 1880s | Price: \$0.25
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Sharecropper

Type: Still bank
Description: African American man with floppy hat and suspenders; similar to Picaninny.
Manufacturer: A.C. Williams, Ohio
Date: 1910 | Price: Unknown
Source: Mechanicalbanksonline.com

Alabama Coon Jigger / Tombo

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Release lever and figure starts an old-fashioned plantation breakdown. Sold 8 million units.
Manufacturer: Ferdinand Strauss Corp., New York City
Date: 1910 | Price: \$0.60
Source: Antiquetoycollections.info

Amos 'n' Andy

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Based on the popular minstrel show.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1930-31 | Price: \$0.48-1.39
Source: Spero 1988

Aunt Chloe / Washerwoman

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: African American woman washing clothes in tub.
Manufacturer: Ives Co., Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1880-85 | Price: Unknown
Source: Prices4antiques.com

Banjo Player

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Seated black man with banjo in bold clothing; stomps foot and moves body when activated.
Manufacturer: Jerome B. Secor Manufacturing, Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1876 | Price: Unknown
Source: Liveauctioneers.com

Brudder Bones

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: End man; waves arms, bends body, shakes head in genuine negro minstrel style.
Manufacturer: Jerome B. Secor Manufacturing, Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1879 | Price: \$4.00
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Chicken Snatcher

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Scared-looking figure shuffles along with chicken in hand and dog hanging on pants. Very funny toy.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1926 | Price: \$0.45
Source: Spero 1988

Charleston Trio

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Charleston Charlie dances while small figure fiddles and dog nods approval.

Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1926-31 | Price: \$0.45
Source: Spero 1988

Ham and Sam the Minstrel Team

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: African American banjo player and piano player.
Manufacturer: Ferdinand Strauss Corp., New York City
Date: 1921 | Price: \$1.00
Source: lcollector.com

Jazzbo Jim

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Similar to Alabama Coon Jigger but also holding banjo.
Manufacturer: Ferdinand Strauss Corp., New York City
Date: ca. 1910-20s | Price: Unknown
Source: Auctionengine.net

Mechanical Cake Walk

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Dancing African Americans.
Manufacturer: Marshall Field & Co.
Date: 1890-93 | Price: \$33.00/dozen
Source: Barlow 1998

Moving Apple Man

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Cloth dressed figure sitting in apple cart; when wound, runs backward as if driving the cart with feet.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1911 | Price: \$0.45
Source: Barlow 1998

Old Colored Fiddler

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Face and expression so funny that they provoke laughter wherever shown.
Manufacturer: Marshall Field & Co.
Date: 1890-93 | Price: \$24.00/dozen
Source: Barlow 1998

Old Nurse

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Old nurse holding white child; handsomely and strongly made, appropriately dressed.
Manufacturer: Ives Co., Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1890-93 | Price: \$24.00/dozen
Source: Barlow 1998

Poor Old Joe

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Mechanical banjo player; picks banjo, turns head, sways body, pats time with foot.
Manufacturer: Jerome B. Secor Manufacturing, Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1879 | Price: \$3.50
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Sister Lucinda at the Play

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Stout elderly lady looking at a play; shakes head, sways body, fans herself vigorously.
Manufacturer: Jerome B. Secor Manufacturing, Bridgeport, CT

Date: 1879 | Price: \$4.00
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

Tip Top Porter

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: African American porter pushing baggage cart.
Manufacturer: Ferdinand Strauss Corp., New York City
Date: 1920s | Price: \$0.50
Source: Wallystoys.com

Uncle Tom (clockwork)

Type: Clockwork toy
Description: Elderly figure setting out on travels; moves legs and walks in natural, life-like manner.
Manufacturer: Jerome B. Secor Manufacturing, Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1879-80 | Price: \$2.60
Source: Mechanicalbanks.org

The Negro Porter Pushes His Cart

Type: Mechanical push toy
Description: Wind up and porter walks across floor, pushing cart ahead of him.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: 1921 | Price: \$0.39
Source: Spero 1988

Jolly Darkey Target Game

Type: Target game
Description: Throw balls into the Darkie's mouth; each ball that goes in scores a point.
Manufacturer: Milton Bradley, Springfield, MA
Date: 1890 | Price: Unknown
Source: Boardgamegeek.com

Tip the Bell Boy

Type: Target game
Description: Shoot the ball into the boy's trays.
Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck
Date: ca. 1929 | Price: \$0.48
Source: Spero 1988

Niggerhead Cap Pistol

Type: Cap pistol
Description: Figure of a black man makes up the handle; cap inserted into mouth, hammer strikes cap setting it off.
Manufacturer: Shepard Hardware Co., Buffalo, NY
Date: 1887 | Price: Unknown
Source: Toyrepair.com

Sambo Cap Pistol

Type: Cap pistol
Description: Similar to above.
Manufacturer: Ives Co., Bridgeport, CT
Date: 1887 | Price: Unknown
Source: Toyrepair.com

Darky in a Watermelon

Type: Doll set
Description: Opening the watermelon (papier mache) reveals a small figure in cloth diaper with nursing bottle.
Manufacturer: Unknown

Date: Probably 20th century | Price: \$0.15 each / \$1.35/dozen
Source: Thetoyzone.com

Golliwog

Type: Rag doll

Description: Grotesque figure with very dark skin, large white-rimmed eyes, red or white clown lips, wild frizzy hair; dressed in jacket, trousers, bow tie.

Manufacturer: Steiff Co., Germany

Date: 1908 | Price: Unknown

Source: Ferris.edu/jimcrow/golliwog

Masquerade Mask (Old Uncle Joe / Topsy)

Type: Costume mask

Description: Negro masks.

Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck

Date: 1921 | Price: \$0.67-0.79

Source: Spero 1988

Negro Minstrel Suit

Type: Costume

Description: Yellow cloth trousers, black coat with broad yellow lapels. Wig with kinky effect.

Manufacturer: Sears and Roebuck

Date: 1921 | Price: Costume \$0.38; Mask \$0.39

Source: Spero 1988

References

- The Antiques Journal (1961). Mechanical Banks: A Survey. <http://www.mechanicalbanks.org>
- Barrett, T. (2003). Interpreting visual culture. *Art Education* 56(2): 6-12.
- Barlow, R.S. (1998). The great American antique toy bazaar: 5,000 old engravings from original trade catalogs, 1879-1946. Windmill, California.
- Baxter, J.E. (2005). The archaeology of childhood: children, gender, and material culture. AltaMira, Walnut Creek.
- Berlin, I. (1998). Many thousands gone: the first two centuries of slavery in North America. Belknap, Cambridge.
- Bourdieu, P. (1977). Outline of a theory of practice. Cambridge University Press, Cambridge.
- Brighton, S.A. (2005). An Historical Archaeology of the Irish Proletarian Diaspora. Doctoral dissertation. Boston University.
- Brighton, S.A. (2008). Degrees of alienation: the material evidence of the Irish and Irish American experience, 1850-1910. *Historical Archaeology* 42(4): 132-153.
- Brown, B. (2006). Reification, reanimation, and the American uncanny. *Critical Inquiry* 32: 175-207.
- Calvert, K.L.F. (1992). Children in the house: the material culture of early childhood, 1600-1900. Northeastern University Press, Boston.
- Chudacoff, H. (2007). Children at play: an American history. New York University Press, New York.
- Cook, D.T. (2004). The commodification of childhood. Duke University Press, Durham.
- Cross, G. (1997). Kid's stuff: toys and the changing world of American childhood. Harvard University Press, Cambridge.
- Dommasnes, L.H. and Wrigglesworth, M. (2008). Children identity and the past. Cambridge Scholars, Newcastle.
- Emerine, A. (1941). What is the Worth of an Old Penny Bank or even an Old Rusty Cap Pistol? <http://www.mechanicalbanks.org>
- Engmann, R. (2007). Ceramic dolls and figurines, citizenship and consumer culture in Market Street Chinatown, San Jose. Unpublished archaeological report, Stanford University.
- Farmer, J.S. (1889). Americanisms, Old and New. Thomas Poulter and Sons, London.
- Ganaway, B. (2007). Engineers or artists? Toys, class, and technology in Wilhelmine Germany. *Journal of Social History* 42: 371-401.
- Griffith, F.H. (1955). Chinaman in Boat with Rat on Tray. *Hobbies Magazine*, May.
- Griffith, F.H. (1959). Reclining Chinaman Bank. *Hobbies Magazine*, December.
- Griffith, F.H. (1963a). The J. & E. Stevens Co. *Hobbies Magazine*, March.
- Griffith, F.H. (1963b). Bailey's Banks. *Hobbies Magazine*, February.
- Griffith, F.H. (1975). Humpty Dumpty Bank. *Hobbies Magazine*.
- Howe, D.W. (1977). Victorian culture in America. In Howe, D.W. (ed.), *Victorian America*. University of Pennsylvania Press, Philadelphia, pp. 3-28.
- Ignatiev, N. (1995). How the Irish became white. Routledge, New York.
- Jacobson, L. (2008). Children and consumer culture in American society. Praeger, Westport.
- Lillehammer, G. (1989). A child is born: the child's world in an archaeological perspective. *Norwegian Archaeological Review* 22: 89-105.
- Mercier, D. (n.d.). From hostility to reverence: 100 years of African-American imagery in games. <http://www.ferris.edu/jimcrow/links/games/>
- Mergen, B. (1982). Play and playthings: a reference guide. Greenwood, Westport.
- Morphy, D. (2007). The official price guide to mechanical banks. House of Collectibles, New York.
- Mullins, P.R. (2000). Race and affluence: an archaeology of African America and consumer culture. Springer, New York.

- Orser, C.E. Jr. (1998). The archaeology of the African diaspora. *Annual Review of Anthropology* 27: 63-82.
- Orser, C.E. Jr. (2004). *Race and the practice of archaeological interpretation*. University of Pennsylvania Press, Philadelphia.
- Orser, C.E. Jr. (2007). *The archaeology of race and racialization in historic America*. University Press of Florida, Gainesville.
- Paddison, J. (2009). Anti-Catholicism and race in post-war San Francisco. *Pacific Historical Review* 78: 505-544.
- Paynter, R. (2001). The Cult of Whiteness in western New England. In Orser, C.E. Jr. (ed.), *Race and the archaeology of identity*. University of Utah Press, Salt Lake City, pp. 125-142.
- Roediger, D.R. (1991). *The wages of whiteness: race and the making of the American working class*. Verso, London.
- Shackel, P.A. (2003). *Memory in black and white: race, commemoration, and the post-bellum landscape*. AltaMira, Walnut Creek.
- Shackel, P.A. (2009). *The archaeology of American labor and working class life*. University Press of Florida, Gainesville.
- Sofaer Derevenski, J. (2000). *Children and material culture*. Routledge, New York.
- Somerville, K. (in press). A place for everything and everything in its place: The cultural context of late Victorian toys. In Coskunsu, G. (ed.), *Proceedings of the IEMA third annual visiting scholar conference*. SUNY Press, Albany.
- Spero, J. (1988). *Collectible toys and games of the twenties and thirties from Sears, Roebuck and Co. Catalogs*. Dover.
- Wilkie, L.A. (2000). Not merely child's play: creating a historical archaeology of children and childhood. In Derevenski, J.S. (ed.), *Children and material culture*. Routledge, New York, pp. 100-113.
- Wilkinson, D.Y. (1974). Racial socialization through children's toys: a sociohistorical examination. *Journal of Black Studies* 5: 96-109.
- Wylie, A. (1996). The constitution of archaeological evidence. In Galison, P. and Stump, D.J. (eds.), *The disunity of science*. Stanford University Press, Stanford, pp. 311-343.
- Yellow Bird, M. (2004). Cowboys and Indians: Toys of genocide, icons of American colonialism. *Wicazo Sa Review* 19(2): 33-48.
- Yamin, R. (2002). Children's strikes, adult games: archaeology and tenement life in lower Manhattan. In Mrozowski, S.A. et al. (eds.), *The archaeology of the Boott Mills boardinghouses*. University of Massachusetts Press, Amherst.